

the IBM T42 simply failed to run *Half-Life 2*. The Toshiba Satellite M30 running on a GeForce Go 5200 and the MSI MegaBook M510C with an ATi Mobility 9700 chip were the exceptions, and fared well in both games.

Finally, it was time to test the battery life. Most of the laptops we tested supported some form of speed throttling—wherein the CPU runs faster or slower depending on the load—and they also switch off the screen and park the drive after a while in order to extract the most from the battery. We wanted to test them under extreme conditions, however, and therefore disabled these features. Keep in mind, therefore, that real-world battery life will be better than what our tests reflect.

The Acer TravelMate 4002 was indeed a traveller's friend—it ran for a whole 230 minutes. On the other extreme were the models from Wipro, which drained out in just 66 minutes, which is poor by any standards.



Acer TravelMate 4002WNLc

Conclusion

While both the IBM T42 and the Toshiba M30 put up a solid performance in most tests, the

Acer TravelMate 4002 came out on top as the best performer.

This wide-screen wonder with a 1.6 GHz Pentium M processor and 512 MB of DDR333 RAM sported a 60 GB hard drive and an 802.11g wireless card. The screen supported a native resolution of 1280 x 800, a resolution ideal for both work and leisure. Being powered by the ATi Mobility Radeon 9700 did not hurt its performance either. Although it weighs in at 2.98 kg, the performance is well worth the extra kilogram!

The MSI MegaBook M510C came in second, closely following the Acer. With a 1.5 GHz Intel processor and 256 MB of DDR333 RAM, the Acer also sports Gigabit Ethernet and an SD/MMC/MemoryStick card reader. This laptop had an 80 GB hard disk, which was the highest capacity in the comparison test.

THE ULTRA-PORTABLES

While the Workhorses are meant to replace your desktop PCs, ultra-portables are designed to be as small and as light as possible. Their screen size is therefore small—less than 14 inches—and they weigh less than two kgs.

A small form factor calls for some compromises though, including the screen size, which may lead to eye strain after prolonged use—and a smaller keyboard, which can be cumbersome to work with. We tested five such models from five different vendors.

Features

All the ultra-portables were based on Intel's Centrino platform: with an Intel Pentium M processor, the Intel 855 chipset and an Intel Pro Wi-Fi chipset.

The Fujitsu S2020, with an AMD Athlon XP-M 2100+, was the exception. The Acer TravelMate 381TCi had a whopping 512 MB of RAM, a lot for its size!

All these laptops had a 4:3 screen, except for the Zenith VU, which featured a 16:9 wide screen. The Zenith Presidio VU also had the highest resolution of 1280 x 768 pixels; the other laptops featured 1024 x 768. The Zenith's only drawback was a 'mirror finish' screen, which was very distracting—it reflected too much light. The Fujitsu LifeBook S2020 had the largest screen size of 13.3 inches, and was a lot easier on the eyes.



MSI MegaBook M510C

'Lighter Laptops Make Sense'



Dr Uday Lajmi
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Studies

Dr Lajmi has equipped himself with an ultra-portable laptop. Why an ultra-portable one? "Weight and size were the two things I was looking at, and it's only an ultra-portable that fits the bill. I often have to lug the laptop around for presentations, so a lighter laptop makes more sense. Moreover, the small size ensures you can take it almost anywhere."

The Toshiba Satellite M30 running on a GeForce Go 5200 chip fared well in both games

The Zenith Presidio VU had three USB 2.0 ports, while the others only had two. The almost-obsolete serial port was only available on the Fujitsu LifeBook S2020, which also sported a parallel port—along with the ACI Ethos Lite.

All these laptops had a FireWire port. They also all had a PCMCIA slot that supported Type I and II PC Cards. Due to their small size, the support for the thicker PCMCIA Type III was absent. The Zenith Presidio VU supported SD/MemoryStick/MMC cards, whereas the ACI Ethos Lite supported SD/MMC—and the Toshiba Portégé M100 supported only SD cards. The rest had no memory card reading capability at all.

IrDA ports were present on all laptops except the Toshiba Portégé M100. It doesn't hurt to have an IrDA port onboard, especially if you wish to transfer files between a cell phone and the laptop.

All the Centrino-certified laptops, as well as the Fujitsu LifeBook S2020, had Wi-Fi connectivity, which is fast getting popular in offices, airport lounges, hotels, and even a few retail outlets.

The Acer TravelMate 381TCi, Fujitsu LifeBook S2020 and the Zenith Presidio VU supported the 802.11b/g standard, while the rest supported the 802.11b standard. It should be noted that the faster 802.11g (54 Mbps) should be preferred over the older and slower 802.11b (11 Mbps). None of the ultra-portables supported Bluetooth. However, all were equipped with a 10/100 Mbps LAN port as well as an internal 56 Kbps modem.

All the laptops came with a 40 GB hard drive, except for the Acer TravelMate 381TCi, which had 60 GB. Only the Toshiba Portégé M100 had a 5,400 rpm hard